

The Lone Woman of San Nicolas Island.

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About eighty miles south of Ventura is a wind-swept island which has the appearance of having been gently lifted from the depths of the ocean. Its altitude is about 800 feet above the sea level. It is surrounded by comparatively low banks, with gradual acclivity until terminating in abrupt escarpments, the surface of the island being comparatively level. This island has a mean length of about nine miles and an average width of about four miles. The longer axis is nearly east and west. Geologically speaking it is of recent origin. The fossils, which are numerous in some places, are of Quaternary age, except some found in the south-eastern portion which may probably be classed as Pliocene. At the present time the island is treeless. It contains neither tree or shrub, except a small species of thorn and the tree cactus, neither of which obtain a height of more than two or three feet. But it has not always been so, for there are evidences existing which indicate that it was once covered with timber. Capt. Nidever, who frequently visited the island, speaks of trees, bushes and moss, forty years ago. Much of the surface is covered with dead land shells—*helix (euparypha) trioni* and *helix (arionta) gabbi*. When they flourished there must have been much vegetation on the island. Their large size and vast numbers are noticeable.

We speak of the island as being "wind-swept," but this is only at certain seasons of the year, while at other times it is calm and serene. During the season that wind prevails it is difficult to land and more difficult for vessels to remain at anchor. The writer spent three weeks on the island in Oct., 1889, and several times during his stay saw the sea lashed into fury, the waves and spray rolled up thirty feet high, and dashed against the rock-ribbed shore with a noise like thunder, and seemed to cause the very atmosphere to tremble. Never before had we witnessed such wild and fierce struggle of the waves, though for many years accustomed to the ocean. One whole day and two nights we could not leave our tent, which was securely anchored to the side of a hill, because of the high wind and drifting sand.

When Cabrillo sailed up this coast three hundred and fifty years ago, he seems not to have discovered San Nicolas island; nor was it seen by Vancouver during his voyage a hundred years ago. The earliest voyagers who visited this island, of which we have an account, named it "Sea Otter Island," because of the great number of sea otters found there. They are still found to a limited extent; also seals, sea lions and numberless aquatic birds. Several species of land birds are found here, and a small fox, *vulpus*

littoralis. The skeletons of two species of dogs are numerous on the island. They were living as late as 1853 and were domesticated by the natives.

The island was once thickly inhabited as the vast shell heaps—kjökkenmöddings—indicate. The relics found are generally of superior workmanship to those found on the other islands and on the mainland, and indicate contact with northern tribes. The barbed spear points or lances used in taking fish, many of which remain, are not found on the other islands of the Santa Barbara channel group. They fashioned many singular implements from stone and bone, the use of which is a puzzle to archaeologists. The opinion has long prevailed that there was a somewhat higher civilization, if such it could be called, here than was found on the mainland and the other islands, and it is said that the inhabitants were of a superior physical mould, the women were tall and handsome and of lighter complexion than other natives of this region.

In an early day the Russians were in the habit of visiting San Nicolas island in quest of the valuable fur of the sea otter. They brought with them natives from Alaska whom they taught the use of fire-arms. It is said that they left some of these on the island to continue the work of capturing otters while the Russian vessels sailed north. While absent these Alaskan Indians took possession of the women on the island, and in the conflict which followed all of the men and male children were killed. When the Russian ships returned and took them away the women were abandoned to their fate. This was some-

time previous to the year 1835. In some way the news reached the Mission fathers, and in the above named year they secured a schooner, the *Peor es Nada*, to go to the island and bring away the remaining inhabitants. The vessel was chartered by Lewis F. Burton and Isaac J. Sparks of Santa Barbara, and was commanded by Charles Hubbard. The crew with two or three exceptions were Kanakas. An American known as Bill Williams accompanied the vessel. They sailed to the island about the first of August, 1835.

After collecting the Indians on the beach ready for embarking, one of them made signs that her child had been left behind, and she was permitted to go in search of it. While absent a strong wind arose which threatened the safety of the schooner, when the officers and crew were compelled to set sail leaving the unfortunate woman and her child behind. They ran before the wind to San Pedro where the Indians were landed, some being taken to Los Angeles and others to San Gabriel Mission. The vessel, which was owned in Monterey, was ordered north to take a load of lumber from that place to San Francisco. In attempting to enter the Golden Gate the *Peor es Nada* was capsized and lost. There being no other craft larger than Indian canoes on this portion of the coast, no effort was made to rescue the woman, and there being no communication with the island from the mainland, the fact of her being left alone gradually passed out of mind.

In 1851 Capt John Nidever of Santa Barbara sailed to the island in quest of the valuable fur of the sea otter. He landed on the lower

or eastern end of the island, when he and a man named Jeffries walked for several miles along the north shore line and discovered human tracks, and some other evidences of life. Before midday, however, a strong wind began to blow, and compelled them to return to their schooner. This continued for several days when they weighed anchor and left the island.

In the winter of 1852 Capt. Nidever made a second visit to this island, having seen a large number of otter on his previous visit. He was now accompanied by a man named Brown and two Indians. He and Brown walked along the shore, as he had done on the occasion of his first visit, but discovered no signs of human occupancy of the island until near evening when they found a basket in the crotch of a small tree. Removing the sealskin covering they discovered a dress or gown made of bird-skins cut in squares, a sinew rope, bone needles, abalone fish-hooks, etc. They remained for several days but failed to see the woman to whom these things afterward proved to belong. About the fifth day a strong southwest wind began to blow which increased to a gale. Waiting for several days, for the wind to calm, they with difficulty got away from the island and sailed to San Miguel island.

In July 1853 Capt. Nidever again sailed to San Nicolas island, and with the avowed purpose to thoroughly explore it in search of the lost woman. His crew consisted of Charles Brown, one Irishman and four Mission Indians. They anchored at Coral Harbor on the north side of the island. Here is a small bay that is entered by passing through a rift in the rocks about twenty feet wide.

At that time it probably offered good anchorage, but is now filling with drifting sand. From this place the party went to the western portion of the island, where Brown discovered human footprints, but they were unable to find the woman. They renewed the search next day and discovered her in a wickup or circular enclosure made of brush somewhat westward of the center of the island. When they came upon her she was removing the blubber from a seal. She arose with dignity, saluting the men with a smile. She was dressed in a gown made of bird skins, the feathers pointing downward. It was cut low at the neck and came down to her ankles. Her hair was a yellowish brown, probably caused in part from exposure. The woman was apparently about fifty years old. After roasting some nuts for her guests, and of which they partook with a relish, they made signs for her to accompany them to the vessel, which after being understood she did without hesitancy, each carrying some of her meager effects. The party remained on the island for a month, the woman proving helpful in bringing wood and water. She gave evidence in various ways of having seen much suffering during the eighteen years of her isolation, but was very cheerful and remained so until the last.

After the schooner set sail for Santa Barbara a storm came on, when the rescued woman fell upon her knees and prayed. When the storm abated, and a patch of blue sky appeared, she pointed to it with pride as much as to say she did it. On reaching Santa Barbara she became an object of great interest to all the country around, and many visited her. Three of the Mission

fathers, Gonzales, Sanchez and Jimeno came to see her, and although they were acquainted with many dialects, yet they could not understand her's nor could she understand them. Indians were brought from Santa Ynez, Los Angeles, and other places, but were unable to converse with her.

While she was an object of curiosity, nearly everything she saw was curious to her. A yoke of oxen drawing an old Spanish cart greatly excited her attention. One of the first to visit her on her arrival at the residence of Capt. Nidever, was Dr. J. B. Shaw, on horseback. Several years ago the doctor narrated to the writer the circumstances of his visit. When the woman saw him riding toward her she seemed to think the horse and rider one; and when she saw him dismount her amazement was great. She came and sat beside him, felt of his clothing and seemed to look upon him as a supernatural being.

The food of civilization, of which she partook to excess, did not agree with her, but brought on sickness of which she died about four weeks after landing at Santa Barbara, or two months after her rescue. While she had probably entirely forgotten her own dialect, and during the eighteen years of her weary solitude had probably constructed another, known only to herself, yet she soon became an adept in conversing by signs. The family of Capt. Nidever, with whom she lived, became very much attached to her. She gave them to understand that when she went back for her child she found that it had been killed and devoured by dogs. She laid down and cried for a long time and became emaciated from grief, but finally recovered. She sometimes saw ships sailing on the ocean, but none came to her rescue. After her

death her gown of bird skins, and various trinkets, were sent to Rome, where they may probably still be seen among the collections and curiosities of the vatican.

The object of the writer in preparing and publishing this history at the present time, is in answer to certain statements that have found their way into print denying the authenticity of the story. That it is literally true there can be no doubt whatever. We received it from Capt. Nidever's own lips several years before his death. The writer was personally acquainted with him from 1874 until his death which occurred about 1886. He was much respected in Santa Barbara where he lived more than fifty years. We never heard his integrity called in question by anyone. In our visit to the islands we found much confirmatory evidence of Mr. Nidever's statements. The account may also be found in the archives of the Santa Barbara Mission preserved by the Mission fathers. We secured a translation of their record of the event by a competent Spanish scholar some fifteen years ago.

Dr. J. B. Shaw, an educated physician, who came from England and settled in Santa Barbara at an early day, and who saw the woman after her rescue, was well acquainted with the facts as related above. He is still living, and is a gentleman of unquestioned integrity. John Nidever, a nephew of Capt. Nidever, was well acquainted with the facts under consideration, and lives in Carpinteria, Cal. Others who saw the woman and are conversant with the facts related in this paper, are still living. In short, no event that occurred on this coast forty or fifty years ago can be better established by written history and living witnesses, than the story of the Lone Woman of San Nicolas Island.